

Self-Care for Mental Health

Evidence-based self-care practices and when they are not enough on their own

Introduction

Self-care has become a widely used term, but it has a specific, evidence-based meaning in the context of mental health. This document explains what self-care means, how it supports mental health, practical self-care strategies, and, importantly, when self-care is not enough and professional help is needed.

What is Self-Care?

The National Institute of Mental Health defines self-care as taking the time to do things that help a person live well and improve both their physical health and mental health. Self-care can help manage stress, lower the risk of illness, and increase energy. Even small acts of self-care in daily life can have a meaningful impact.

(Source: NIMH)

Mental health includes emotional, psychological, and social well-being. It affects how people think, feel, act, make choices, and relate to others. Mental health is more than the absence of a mental illness; it is essential to overall health and quality of life. Self-care can play a role in maintaining mental health, and it can also help support treatment and recovery for a person who has a mental illness.

(Source: NIMH)

Self-care looks different for everyone, and it is important to find what works and what a person actually needs and enjoys. It may take some trial and error to discover what works best for a given individual.

(Source: NIMH)

Why Self-Care Matters

Self-care is not a cure for mental illness, but understanding what triggers mild symptoms and which coping techniques are effective for a specific person can help that person manage their mental health more effectively over time. Self-care practices support the body and mind in ways that build resilience against everyday stress and can reduce the risk of symptoms becoming more severe.

(Source: NIMH)

Evidence-Based Self-Care Practices

Physical Self-Care

- Get regular exercise: even just 30 minutes of walking every day can help boost mood and improve health. Smaller amounts of activity add up over the course of a day, so a single long session is not required.
- Eat healthy, regular meals and stay hydrated: a balanced diet and adequate water can improve energy and focus throughout the day.
- Make sleep a priority: stick to a consistent sleep schedule, and reduce exposure to blue light from phones and computers before bedtime, since it can make it harder to fall asleep.

(Source: NIMH)

Emotional and Mental Self-Care

- Set goals and priorities: decide what must get done now and what can wait, and learn to say no to new tasks when already feeling overwhelmed.
- Practice gratitude: remind yourself daily of specific things you are grateful for, whether by writing them down or reflecting on them.
- Focus on positivity: identify and challenge negative or unhelpful thoughts rather than accepting them automatically.
- Be mindful of what you have accomplished at the end of the day, rather than focusing only on what was not completed.
- Schedule regular time for activities you enjoy, such as journaling, reading, or hobbies.

(Source: NIMH)

Social Self-Care

- Stay connected: reach out to friends or family members who can provide emotional support and practical help.
- Even joining a community group can help build the human connection that supports mental health.

(Source: NIMH)

Common Barriers to Self-Care

- Believing self-care is selfish or unnecessary, rather than recognizing it as a legitimate part of maintaining health.
- Difficulty finding time due to work, caregiving, or other responsibilities.
- Not knowing which self-care practices are likely to help, since self-care looks different for each individual.
- Assuming self-care alone should be enough to manage more serious symptoms, when in fact professional support may be needed alongside it.

(Source: NIMH)

Healthy Lifestyle Recommendations

Self-care is closely tied to everyday lifestyle habits, since physical health and mental health are deeply connected.

(Source: NIMH)

- Build regular physical activity into the day, even in short increments.
- Prioritize consistent, adequate sleep.
- Eat balanced, regular meals and limit excess caffeine.
- Reduce screen time, particularly before bed.
- Make time for activities that bring genuine enjoyment or relaxation.

(Source: NIMH)

Self-Help Techniques

- Keep a simple gratitude practice, noting a few specific things you are thankful for each day.
- Practice saying no to additional commitments when your plate is already full.
- Try journaling to process thoughts and track patterns in mood or triggers.
- Set small, achievable goals rather than overwhelming, open-ended ones.
- Reach out proactively to a friend or family member rather than waiting until you feel isolated.
- Experiment with different self-care activities, since it may take trial and error to find what genuinely helps.

(Source: NIMH)

When Self-Care Is Not Enough: Seeking Professional Help

While self-care is an important part of maintaining and supporting mental health, it is not a substitute for professional treatment when symptoms are severe or persistent. Professional help should be sought if a person is experiencing severe or distressing symptoms that have lasted two weeks or more.

(Source: NIMH)

- Thinking about suicide or harming yourself or others.
- Feeling extremely fatigued, tired, or unable to sleep.
- Feeling as if nothing matters, or a loss of interest in things you used to enjoy.
- Experiencing unexplained aches and pains.
- Feeling helpless or hopeless.
- Engaging in behaviors that harm yourself or others, such as excessive drinking or drug use.
- Feeling unusually confused, forgetful, on edge, angry, upset, worried, or scared.

- Yelling or fighting with family and friends.
- Experiencing severe mood swings that cause problems in relationships.
- Being unable to carry out daily activities or handle daily problems and stress.

(Source: NIMH)

A person should not wait until symptoms are overwhelming to seek help. Talking with a primary care provider is a good first step; the provider can refer the person to a qualified mental health professional, such as a psychologist, psychiatrist, or clinical social worker, who can help identify next steps.

(Source: NIMH)

If a person, or someone they know, is struggling or having thoughts of suicide, they should call or text the 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline (in the United States) or chat at 988lifeline.org. In a life-threatening situation, call 911 or local emergency services immediately.

(Source: NIMH)

Myths vs Facts

- Myth: Self-care is indulgent or selfish. Fact: Self-care is a legitimate, evidence-based way to support mental and physical health, and it is recognized by the National Institute of Mental Health as playing a role in maintaining mental health and supporting treatment and recovery.
- Myth: Self-care requires a lot of time or money. Fact: Even small acts of self-care, such as a short walk or a few minutes of journaling, can have a meaningful impact.
- Myth: Self-care can replace professional treatment for serious symptoms. Fact: Self-care is not a cure for mental illness, and professional help should be sought for severe or distressing symptoms lasting two weeks or more.
- Myth: The same self-care practices work for everyone. Fact: Self-care looks different for everyone, and it often takes trial and error to find what works best for a given individual.

(Source: NIMH)

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: What counts as self-care?

A: Self-care is any activity that helps a person live well and improve their physical and mental health. This can include physical activities like exercise and sleep, emotional practices like gratitude and goal-setting, and social activities like staying connected with friends and family.

(Source: NIMH)

Q: Is self-care a substitute for therapy or medical treatment?

A: No. Self-care can support mental health and help with treatment and recovery, but it is not a cure for mental illness. Professional help should be sought for severe or distressing symptoms lasting two weeks or

more.

(Source: NIMH)

Q: How much exercise is recommended for mental health benefits?

A: Even about 30 minutes of walking a day can help boost mood and improve health, and smaller amounts of activity throughout the day can add up if a longer session is not possible.

(Source: NIMH)

Q: When should I talk to a health care provider about my mental health?

A: A person should talk to a primary care provider if they are experiencing severe or distressing symptoms that have lasted two weeks or more, rather than waiting until symptoms become overwhelming.

(Source: NIMH)

Key Takeaways

- Self-care means taking time to do things that help a person live well and support both physical and mental health.
- Self-care looks different for everyone, and effective practices are often found through trial and error.
- Evidence-based self-care practices include regular exercise, balanced nutrition, consistent sleep, gratitude, goal-setting, and staying socially connected.
- Self-care supports mental health but is not a cure for mental illness and should not replace professional treatment when needed.
- Severe or distressing symptoms lasting two weeks or more warrant contacting a health care provider.
- Any thoughts of self-harm or suicide require immediate professional help.

This document provides general educational information based on publicly available guidance from the National Institute of Mental Health. It is not a substitute for personalized medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Always consult a qualified health care provider with questions about a specific medical condition.

References

- Caring for Your Mental Health — National Institute of Mental Health (NIMH).
<https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/topics/caring-for-your-mental-health>